converts should follow. Afterwards, the apostle Paul himself used the decisions of this first church council to point out—rather sharply—errors in the way his fellow apostle Peter was handling himself around Gentiles.*

But he did not label Peter a heretic. For *heresy* to exist—not just individual error, but belief that stepped all the way outside the framework of the Christian faith—there had to *be* a framework.

This had been provided by the emperor Constantine all the way back in 325, when he had called all Christian bishops together at Nicaea to hammer out a creed, a statement of orthodoxy. The Nicene Creed was the first official fence built around the Christian faith to define who was in and who was out.*And the Nicene Creed, approved by Constantine, also created the ability to punish heresy with the sword. Before Nicaea, Christians could accuse each other of error all they wanted, but argument and excommunication were the sharpest swords they could wield. After Nicaea, bishops had much more power: they could ask the emperor to enforce the creed he had sponsored with political might.

Not everyone thought this was a good idea—particularly those who happened to be on the outside of the creed. Writing nearly a century later, Augustine notes that the fourth-century heretics known as Donatists complained that "the apostles never sought such measures from the kings of the earth." But, Augustine continues, that was only because in the apostles' day, the kings of the earth didn't believe in Christ. Now, a Christian king could serve God "by enforcing with suitable rigor such laws as ordain what is righteous, and punish what is the reverse." This included not just wrong actions, but wrong beliefs.

"Why," Augustine asks, "should adulteries be punished by the laws, and sacrilege allowed? Is it a lighter matter that a soul should not keep faith with God, than that a woman should be faithless to her husband?"

> It is indeed better . . . that men should be led to worship God by teaching, than that they should be driven to it by fear of punishment or pain; but . . . many have found advantage (as we have proved, and are daily proving by actual experiment) in being first compelled by fear or pain, so that they might afterwards be influenced by teaching. . . . Why, therefore, should not the Church use force in compelling her lost sons to return?[2]

In the medieval world, heretics had often been duly compelled by fear and pain. But they were not, generally speaking, punished with the sword.† The Theodosian Code of 438 made heresy an imperial crime, but most of the penalties deprived the heretics of property and certain rights; heretics could be